



ACTION, REACTION
PM Modi, defence minister Rajnath Singh and others at a cabinet meeting post Op Sindoor in Delhi, May 7; (below) Pak PM Shehbaz Sharif chairs a National Security Committee meeting in Islamabad, May 7

deserts or plains. Our mechanised forces and artillery are way ahead of Pakistan," says Lt Gen. Anil K. Ahuja (retd), former director general of military operations. He does add that Pakistan's geography gives it an advantage in terms of mobilisation of forces. "With our commitments along the northern borders with China, where we have disengaged but de-escalation and deinduction have yet to take place, the conventional force levels against Pakistan have reduced. The existing levels remain adequate for retribution, but efforts need to be made to further strengthen deterrence," he says.

The Indian army has 280 artillery regiments equipped with 105mm field guns, Bofors howitzers with upgraded Dhanush and Sharang guns, the ultra-light M-777 howitzers and the K-9 Vajra self-propelled tracked guns. The Pinaka multi-launch rocket systems, Smerch and Grad rockets, UAVs, surveillance systems, missiles and other advanced firepower assets add to the muscle. Pakistan has 25 artil-

> **"PAKISTAN RESERVES THE ABSOLUTE RIGHT TO RESPOND DECISIVELY TO THIS UNPROVOKED INDIAN ATTACK—A RESOLUTE RESPONSE IS ALREADY UNDER WAY"**
>
> **—Shehbaz Sharif**
> *Pakistani PM on X, May 7*

of $79 billion (2025-26) dwarfs Pakistan's $7.6 billion, India has a full-scale military commitment along its northern borders against China, blunting its manpower and equipment edge over Pakistan. Pakistan, too, has to commit troops and firepower to its troubled borders with Afghanistan and Iran, but these are largely for counter-terrorism roles which predominantly involve its infantry.

In terms of land forces—which primarily include the infantry, artillery and armoured corps (tanks)—the Indian army is better positioned than Pakistan. Its three strike corps—I Corps in Mathura, II Corps in Ambala and XXI Corps in Bhopal—are well-placed to take decisive military action against Pakistan. For its part, Pakistan has only two strike corps—I Corp (Mangla in PoK) and II Corp (Multan, Punjab)—both close to the Indian border. "Our armoured formations are right there towards the Pakistan border to launch an offensive on the

lery regiments and has constantly upgraded their firepower, including with the Chinese-made SH-15 self-propelled howitzers it inducted in 2022. The SH-15 integrates cutting-edge tech and is compatible with precision-guided munitions that have enhanced Pakistan's artillery threat profile. In terms of armoured vehicles, India outmatches Pakistan with its 4,200-plus tanks, including the T-90 Bhishma and indigenous Arjun variants, compared to Pakistan's 2,627.

The Air Battles

Military strategists believe it won't be a boots-on-the-ground battle as much as a display of air and missile power. When it comes to air power, India deploys 606 fighters, including the Rafale, Su-30MKI and Mirage 2000, alongside 80 attack helicopters. Its air defence is bolstered by the S-400, Barak-8, Akash and AI-powered situational awareness platforms. The Indian Air Force maintains a vast inventory of air-launched cruise missiles (ALCMs) for deep-strike missions.